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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8WOYq_fQVEM
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:00:02] Okay, and good morning. I would like to welcome everyone to the Board of Education's January work session. Obviously, you can all see once again, we are still here in the Library of Virginia. We had to make some quick shifts over here yesterday afternoon, or most of the day yesterday, our team at the department was working swiftly to make this last minute shift over here.

[00:00:44] based on power issues in the Monroe Building. So thank you all. Huge Herculean effort by staff to get this to come to just, this is nearly seamless, everyone, for exactly what we've gone through over the last 24 hours.

[00:01:01] So your work tirelessly, not just what you do every day, but in the last 24 hours has been so critical to ensuring that the work of the board can continue. And we are so grateful for all of you. So please, please know how much we appreciate you all in the extra hours and sweat and stress that you have taken on here for our benefit and the benefit of the children and teachers and school divisions in the Commonwealth.

[00:01:32] So thank you. Dr. Koons, did you have any opening remarks that you would like to make? I want to thank the team again. I mean, we've had technology shifts, presentation shifts, walking from building to building.

[00:01:47] I also want to thank the general services contractors who work tirelessly over at the James Monroe Building to try and restore power. It has been an interesting journey for us over the past 24 hours. I want to thank them. But also, some of the presentations you're going to hear today involve a tremendous amount of stakeholder input and a tremendous amount of constituents across the Commonwealth, whether they are teachers, principals, superintendents, parents, family members, business members who have really come together and given us great feedback, great guidance, and great thought partnership. So I want to thank those people who have done that already and say thank you to those who will be

[00:02:25] doing that in some of our presentations. After this presentation, it's really important for the department to be shoulder to shoulder in the work with everyone across the Commonwealth, and I'm incredibly grateful that they come out every day to help us and guide us in the direction that we're going. And so with that, I believe we have Ms. Conway up for her presentation this morning. So Ms. Conway, please take it away. Oh, I'm sorry. Excuse me. Mr. Chapman has a public announcement.

[00:02:55] Sorry. Yes. Thank you. Because we're away from the Monroe Building, we are down a little bit of broadcast capabilities. And so for those of the public who would like to follow along, normally We may have the ability to broadcast the presentation along with the live stream, but we're not going to do that today.

[00:03:11] So if you'd like to follow along at home, you can navigate to all the material available during the day section and part of the production. Thank you. Once again, because we're away from the Monroe Building, we are down a little bit of our broadcast capabilities.

[00:03:31] And so, you know, for those members of the public who would like to follow along with the material at home, That's available on the DOE website, which is doe.virginia.gov. And right on that top ribbon, you'll see a number of different blue banner for parents and students, teachers, teaching and learning and assessment.

[00:03:48] You want to click on the state board and data and funding menu. It'll pull a dropdown and right on the left-hand side under Virginia Board of Education, you'll see board meetings, agendas, and minutes. Right there, you should have access to the January 24, 25, 2024 meeting page where all the agenda material is linked for you there thank you and now excellent take it away good morning chair crazy good morning members of the board of education i'm jenna conway i am our deputy superintendent of early childhood care and education and i'm pleased to be here this

[00:04:25] morning to present to you a work session on early childhood and the governor's proposed investment in early childhood in the upcoming budget building blocks for virginia families The slides look like this, if you've got them, and I'll try to remember to walk us through numbers, page numbers as we go. If you move to slide two, the objective of this session today is to first provide a brief overview of our care and education system. Some of you have seen this before, but I realize we have new board members and wanting to make sure that everybody understands

[00:05:02] how this landscape works, what aspects are similar to K-12 and what aspects are unique to early childhood, highlight some of the things that are recognized about our public-private parent choice system, and then share some key details on building blocks for Virginia families. If you move into the school readiness section, our true north, and we always start with our why when we discuss the early childhood system in Virginia, is about school readiness. If you look at slide four, this gives you the chart on school readiness in Virginia. Right now, we know that four out of 10 kids

[00:05:38] enter kindergarten not ready in at least one of the four areas that we measure. We use the Virginia kindergarten readiness program, or VKRP, to evaluate every single child that enters our public schools across the Commonwealth. And we look at four areas, early literacy, early math, self-regulation, and social skills. And right now we know that six out of 10 kids come in fully ready and four out of 10 kids come in not ready. We'll talk in a moment about what that means as you look to the next slide, size five. We also know that there are some significant disparities in who has

[00:06:17] the opportunity to come to school ready and who may not. So overall, if you look at slide five, you'll see that 60% of kids come in ready, but those numbers drop when you look at particular subgroups. So our Black and Hispanic students are less likely to come in ready. Our students with low incomes are less likely to come in ready, as well as our multilingual learners and our children with special needs. And so this data helps when we think about the purpose of the early childhood system, which is ultimately to make sure no matter where you live in the Commonwealth that you have the opportunity to come to school ready. We know that we have some

[00:06:50] issues to tackle as we think about, okay, where do kids and families need the most support? We also know, if you move to slide six, that we have regional variations in readiness. And so sometimes I'll be out there talking with stakeholders or elected officials, and they're like, I'm pretty sure in my community, all the kids are coming in kindergarten ready, right?

[00:07:14] Everybody's above average. And what we see, unfortunately, is that truly across the state, there are readiness challenges no matter where you go. On this regional variations and readiness chart, the blue dot is the percentage of all kids who meet the benchmark coming in. And then the orange dot is the percentage of low-income children who meet the benchmark. So, for example, in southwest Virginia, although we're a little bit lower than the state average in overall readiness, they actually do a better job than most in making sure that low-income children have the opportunity to come in school ready. In contrast, in capital

[00:07:50] area. Those kids are coming in most ready. Just over 63% of them are coming in ready. But then with their low-income children, they have some of the lowest rates, only 42% of children in low-income households in that area are coming ready. So this just gives you a sense, and we can slice and dice this data in lots of different ways, but it really drives our system, our public-private parent system.

[00:08:11] We think about all of the choices that family has and making sure they can choose options that put their kids, no matter where they live, no matter where they're from, what background they might have, what issues they may face, that they have the opportunity to come to school ready. You might say, as we move on to why school night readiness, why do we care so much?

[00:08:29] Some of you might say, I understand the importance of early literacy and math, social skills, but like, why do we care so much about school readiness? And this really stems from what we know now about the rapid brain development between birth and five and why it's so important to intervene.

[00:08:46] This simple graphic just shows you sort of mathematically and visually how much the brain grows during that time. But even more importantly, it's not just the size, but the neural connections on the brain that truly lay the foundation, the foundation for future academic learning and the foundation for the key executive function skills. So that's why we look at social skills and self-regulation at the beginning of kindergarten. It's very hard to be successful in school if you can't manage your emotions, right? We see

that manifest itself most obviously in preschool, but that's true even for middle schoolers and high schoolers, right? And that

[00:09:20] foundation is truly set early in life. If you go to the next slide, slide nine, we also between the MRIs that give you the pictures like you saw in the prior slides, or the research that we've done in this space, we are going further, further back and understanding how much babies and toddlers are learning. So we now even though they're not talking, we know that babies are absorbing language, and we can start to quantify that understanding of words or signs like two cognitive abilities as early as three months. We also know that the level of exposure to words and context

[00:09:56] early on connects to your vocabulary, and vocabulary at 18 months is predictive of future learning. By the time kids are three and four, there are already gaps, unfortunately. We can look at their vocabulary, their attention, their general knowledge, and we can predict, as I'll show in a moment, their third and fourth grade reading comprehension. And then third grade reading, As you've heard from my colleague, Dr. Sorensen and her incredible team, is really important not only to be successful in school, but is directly correlated and a predictor of high school graduation.

[00:10:29] In fact, if you move to slide 10, we know this is true even for Virginia. Let me take a moment. I know some of you have seen this slide before, but it's pretty powerful. This took several cohorts of kids and looked at how they did on the PALS at the beginning of kindergarten. A fairly simple measure of sounds and letters right at the very beginning of kindergarten.

[00:10:48] And then looked at how those very same kids did in third grade. And what this chart shows you is that the kids who came in very ready. So if you look at that gray bar, if you came in very ready to kindergarten, very, you know, sort of on this literacy assessment, that 92% of those kids were reading by third grade, right?

[00:11:06] So that if we can get kids coming in ready, we can almost guarantee this is across the state, right? So the experiences that kids had across kindergarten, first, second, third grade varied widely. But across the state, 92% of those kids were reading on level by third grade. In sharp contrast, as you look to that yellow bar, we know that our kids who came in furthest behind, our systems did everything they could possibly do across that K-1, 2, 3 band, but fewer than half of those kids are reading on level.

[00:11:36] So think about what a different K-12 experience we can have if we can get more of our kids to come in looking like that blue or gray bar. If you go to the next slide, we also know it's not just about academics. We know that it matters for academics, for health and well-being, and employment and earnings. So just a couple of highlights, huge connection between if we can help families build sound routines around attendance in child care or preschool, we know that they're less likely to be chronically absent in elementary school and beyond.

[00:12:06] We know if you're less likely to be absent, you'll get more of the school content, and you'll then do better in school. We also know that you're more likely to be successful in your career, you're less likely to be involved in the criminal justice system, and there are tons of social determinants of health, like just providing a stable early childhood experience that promotes your development very early on truly helps your brain and body be healthier over the long run.

[00:12:32] So with that, I know I've convinced all of you of the importance of this. let me take just a few moments to explain how Virginia's early childhood landscapes works. So our system, if you look at slide

13, is a public-private parent choice system. So it's complicated, and I'll try to simplify it in a set of slides, but it is truly a mix of public and private providers that offer birth-to-five care and education across different settings. We have just under 2,000 family child care homes. So this is child care, smaller number of kids offered in someone's home. We have just under 3,000 licensed child care centers. Some of these are mom and pop,

[00:13:09] very small. Some of these are big commercial centers that you've seen before. Some are in faith-based programs. Some are in secular programs. We have 946 public schools that either offer Virginia Preschool Initiative or some version of locally funded preschool or early childhood special education for our children, two and a half to five with special needs. We've got our religiously exempt. So these are our churches that offer child care options. And then we have Head Start and Early Head Start, which is offered in either schools or in child care centers. This is a federal to local grant that serves our most vulnerable kids and families across the state.

[00:13:44] So an incredible array of programs. What's great about the system is that it truly enables parent choice. So for example, many families of infants and toddlers would prefer a smaller setting when their child is young. The same is true for communities that might be fluent in a language other than English. Other programs or other families might choose. They would like to be able to send their four-year-old to preschool at the same place where their older siblings go at the elementary school. And so choice has always been a really important part of our early childhood system. In this system, you have public dollars. And so this is how the public-private works. But as you may have heard from your constituents, we know that child care in particular can be very

[00:14:24] expensive. And so public funds help make it affordable. And so we provide public funds across a variety of programs that enable families to choose their options. All families are not guaranteed to be served like K-12. So we focus on those in greatest need, and we have different eligibility requirements. And this is how public funds then go to private settings. So some of them are public funds that go to public settings, like preschool in our public elementary schools.

[00:14:51] Some of those are public funds that go to private settings. So you can take a voucher to go to a family child care or child care program. And that allows us to address the diverse needs of families and to have a diverse set of providers who are focused on making sure they meet the needs of families.

[00:15:08] You might say, wow, Jenna, this seems really complicated and a lot to manage. And so there are certain things that since we have moved responsibility for early childhood to the Department of Education in 2020 that we try to make consistent across the settings.

[00:15:23] So we set consistent expectations for health, safety, and learning across those funds if you take public dollars. I'll talk a little bit more about that in a moment. We help coordinate enrollment, and we're working very hard with our regional partners in the field to make it easier for families to understand their options and to be able to apply and enroll in their choice.

[00:15:42] And, and you, as some of my colleagues on the board will know, we capture data down to the classroom level. And so we can geek out for hours on this, but it's really important across this complex system, how do we make sure that we have consistent data and we use that to promote continual quality improvement.

[00:16:01] On the next slide, you'll see an overview of the public funding, the number of children served, the investment per child, the dosage, the family expectations, and the settings. So this in one place gives you a sense of it. The preschool initiative is in the schools. It's predominantly three and four-year-olds, and it's sort of school day, school year. The mixed delivery grant program and the child care subsidy program are full day, full year, birth to five, really enabling working families to be able to work so their kids can be, whether kids are in care or early education, and mostly located in private settings.

[00:16:38] And then Early Head Start and Head Start in a mix of schools and in child care and family day homes and more of that kind of school year, school day calendar. If you go to the next slide, and I promised you that we had data and we do have it down to the classroom level.

[00:16:54] Thanks to the passage in the law of 2020, we have something called BQB5. And this is our new statewide measurement and improvement system. And this body has endorsed or passed the guidelines in the last two years for practice years. And now we're in the first full year. Because we have VQB5 and we have our statewide data system, Link B5, we know exactly how many classrooms we have, where they are, and what ages they are. So we know we have just over 11,000 classrooms in VQB5 across the Commonwealth. These classrooms are not all in schools, right? They're in family child care homes, licensed child care centers, faith-based programs, public school, and Head Start. So again, a kind of a mix.

[00:17:30] And so sometimes I'll do classrooms in quotes because it might be in a home setting, right, where the classroom is her living room into kind of a subset of her kitchen. But you see that this is across the Commonwealth. And again, we have this precision down to the classroom level. We also know as we have rolled out VQB5 and sought to deploy all of the dollars that came down in response to the pandemic, we've had an opportunity in Virginia to make more resources available.

[00:18:02] And in response, families have responded to say how much they want, trust, and need and rely on this system. I often say, as the parent of three young children, there's no greater act of trust than putting your child, particularly your nonverbal child, in early childhood care and education.

[00:18:18] And Virginia families are telling us that they truly trust the system, even with all of the changes in recent years. We saw a dip in overall enrollment. This is all the publicly funded programs that we talked about on the prior slide. During the pandemic, you see we dropped down to an all-time low of just over 50,000 kids.

[00:18:35] And since then, thanks to some of the changes made by the General Assembly, endorsed by this body, we have seen a tremendous growth in enrollment. In fact, we've even updated these slides, and as of this month, we're over 80,000 children statewide, so a really significant increase to where we were pre-pandemic.

[00:18:56] Some of you have heard, we know we have not always necessarily seen the return in enrollment following the pandemic into our K-12 system, but we know that our Virginia Preschool Initiative is back and above its pre-pandemic enrollment, and then we've just seen seismic growth in our mixed delivery program and in our child care subsidy program. So a really significant vote of faith in this system at the same time that we're rolling out important accountability and measurement. If you move to the next slide, again, this growth is everywhere, so I always want to make sure that we're thinking about this not only at the state level, but across the regions. And so this just shows you the growth in private settings, and you just see dramatic

[00:19:35] growth in every single region of the state. A lot of this, if you move to slide 19, we think has to do with what's going on in a good way with the Virginia economy. And so we are at historic rates of labor participation, historic low rates of unemployment. And we think that a lot of that is correlated with having strong early childhood options that offer that full day, full year, so parents can work. This is important because if you look at that sidebar quote on slide 19, two out of three children in Virginia under the age of six have all available parents in the

[00:20:12] workforce. So what that means is if you have two parents, both of them are in the workforce, or if you have a solo parent, that he or she is in the workforce. So it truly becomes a necessity that parents can access high quality early childhood care and education so parents can work. What this chart shows you, and I will try to explain it as I understand it, but probably Ms. Northern could do a better job, but we looked at kind of the early childhood options and unemployment in Virginia, and what we saw was a strong, positive, and statistically significant correlation between participation in our early childhood care and education system,

[00:20:48] overall enrollment and employment, which basically means that when you have greater access to early childhood education, we have higher rates of employment. So these two do go together. So there truly is the dual function of early childhood is to, you know, first and foremost, put kids on track for success, but it's also essential to supporting our working families in Virginia, those who are working, going to school, or actively looking for work. So with all of that context. I'm pleased to take a few moments to explain to you a very exciting budget proposal that came from Governor Youngkin, and that was his first budget announcement in December.

[00:21:24] This is known as Building Blocks for Virginia's Families. My presentation will not be as exciting as the governor's because he happened to have a set of four-year-olds from a nearby child care, child development center, and they did a tremendous job singing. So I promise you, I will spare you singing, although it was a more powerful presentation because of it.

[00:21:45] but it was an exciting moment of recognizing the importance of early childhood in the Commonwealth and a very significant investment in our public-private parent choice system. There are some key principles underlying building blocks for Virginia families. One is really building on the incredible work of the public and private sector over the last years. The pandemic hit early childhood hard as it did our k-12 system and it took heroic effort to get centers and programs back open to get families to trust in our programs again and to bring folks back and

[00:22:22] they did and then they really responded with historic enrollment and making sure that we continue to build on that growth that recognized parent choice so that parents can continue to choose whether that's a home-based provider child care head start public private parochial school and community partnerships and we know largely we think because of some of those economic development elements that two-thirds of virginia families are relying on our public or choosing our public private options we also know that these dollars are essential for our highest need working families child care is simply not affordable if you can't access vpi or a voucher or mixed delivery

[00:23:01] And these families need to be able to choose an option that meets their need. We know at the same time, quality also matters. You could serve more kids if you just threw out all of the principles on health, safety and learning and paid people peanuts. But we also know that that won't actually put kids on track for success.

[00:23:17] And so we are one of the few states in the nation that has a statewide measurement and improvement system. I think one of the few, if not the only one that has a data system that captures data down to the classroom level, which really means that we can make a big investment in the system and track every dollar. We know where every single publicly funded kid is. We know what classroom they're in. We observe that classroom twice a year. We capture that data, and then we will present that data to you all, to stakeholders, and to families starting this fall. And that enables us to continue our focus on child outcomes and really making sure that the experiences that

[00:23:52] kids are receiving, regardless of the name on the outside of the building, the funding source are putting kids on track for success. We were recognized nationally by a study out of Vanderbilt that showed that these investments pay for themselves because of our data system and because we track where every dollar goes, that it showed that families, our Virginia families, are working and earning more, more state tax revenues, and that these investments pay for themselves in less than a year. And then we're trying to continually work with our public-private system to strike the right balance of keeping kids safe, making sure learning is happening, but also allowing

[00:24:27] regional discretion and reducing administrative burden. With that, our governor proposed, and this is literally in play across the street as we speak, that the Commonwealth invests more than $448 million annually, annually, not over the biennium, annually in early childhood care and education. This will help advance our system. It will serve as a response to the loss of the one-time federal funding. So when we met with the commission, a lot of these recommendations came out of a new commission that was established by our legislature. And we were facing a doomsday scenario of 35,000

[00:25:06] kids losing their voucher or slot in early childhood. And so this is this governor and this administration's response by making a significant investment in this area and then helping ensuring that we build on the positive momentum of recent years and build a commonwealth that is the best place to live, work, learn, and raise a family. The first and foremost, this investment preserves every slot. And so that's really important to note that we have 42,000 children on child care subsidy. And data that we presented to House Appropriations and Senate

[00:25:43] finite last week. We show that we're going to serve that many of kids in the over FY25 and 26. We will continue to serve 2,500 kids in mixed delivery. We will continue to serve 25,000 kids, which is an increase in Virginia Preschool Initiative. So a commitment, a true commitment to make sure that nobody is losing their slot as no community, no family, no child is losing their slot as these federal dollars go away. It will continue to accelerate parent choice. And so making sure that we are able to say, we will put the dollars up, we will see what the parents prefer, and then the budget language enables the department to really start to better ensure that

[00:26:23] the dollars follow the child. Historically, there were investments in the VPI, our Virginia Preschool Initiative space, and we could move those dollars if one area of the state needed them and another area of the state didn't, but we couldn't move them to other programs. And so for the last three years running, we have turned back anywhere from 23 to $50 million. That were dollars that were initially supposed to be dedicated to early childhood, but then reverted to state general funds. So this language would allow if for some reason, and we think that we will serve every VPI slot that is asked of us next year, but if for some reason a community does not want to

[00:27:02] use all of their slots, we're able to then turn there where there might be greater demand in child care subsidy or in mixed delivery. We would make sure to spend all the federal dollars first and only use the state dollars when necessary, but a really key flexibility so that we can continue to track and match the dollars based on parental preferences. And it would call on us to continually measure and cap that so we could be transparent with this body in addition to the General Assembly on what was parental demand, what is the unmet demand in terms of families on waitlist? And how do we sort of better advise our folks who make decisions on money on kind of

[00:27:40] what Virginia parents want and prefer at any point in time? We also have that data alongside all of the quality data, right? So we can understand where the dollars are going and ensuring that they meet that minimum quality. The building box for Virginia families would also focus on attendance. And we've got some expectations across the program, but to elevate them and make sure that we help, we are working with our families to reduce any barriers to attendance and that everybody is monitoring and measuring attendance. It would call on making sure that families are

[00:28:14] contributing a reasonable amount, a co-pay for families that are participating in full day, full year, early childhood care, an option that's already a requirement federally for the vouchers. And so adding that as well to mixed delivery and making sure that our families are working, Searching for a job or in school or job training as they pursue greater self-sufficiency. And then there's some innovations in this package. And I know I've talked with some of you on this body about, you know, what's next? How do we continue to grow the supply? How do we make child care more accessible and affordable? And so the governor's proposed budget has two innovative proposals.

[00:28:53] the first is establishing a digital wallet, working to create a technology, a technological mechanism that would enable shared contributions. So the idea is we could work very closely to create some technology. We could work with our regions and businesses and to create a platform where you could give all of the families in a region or at an employer a wallet, and then very easy for the community foundation or the business to make donations to that. So kind of testing and piloting that. And last but certainly not least, it includes a $25 million capital

[00:29:30] incentive fund. And so we know we need more supply. We also know it's expensive to build. And so what this proposes is one-time dollars that would focus on repurposing spaces in partnership with the Department of Housing and Community Development, our State Council on Higher Education, and really encouraging competitive applications from local government and higher education. So imagine on a community college campus or in a government space that's being underutilized, these would be one-time dollars to renovate that space. Even though Virginia received over a billion dollars in child care relief funds over the last few years,

[00:30:08] we couldn't use those for capital purposes beyond some very minor HVAC and kind of COVID-related enhancements. So this would be a chance to work with communities to provide some funding to renovate spaces, buy that equipment, get them in place, the small sinks and the small things needed for teaching us, our little learners, and hopefully increase the supply of childcare slots across the commonwealth. So those are the parts of the budget. We do have a lot more detail and I

[00:30:42] can share, I will spare you, slides that you need, a sort of a looking glass to examine, a microscope to examine but we are incredibly excited that this administration has made a commitment to build on the work of this body of the extraordinary public private stakeholders across the state to fund

every slot to honor and elevate parent choice to make some policy shifts to make this program sustainable and to pilot some innovations that would help us increase supply engage a broader set of business and local government and higher ed stakeholders

[00:31:20] Would you mind just reminding this group in the public about the ECCE Commission and some of the work they've done? I think you did a great job talking about where we are now, but that group has done and that body has done a significant amount of work over the past year. No, that's a great question. So the and I should note in the in the governor's presentation early December, recognizing the incredible work of the new commission on early childhood care and education.

[00:31:48] So this is a bipartisan commission that included legislators, business leaders, stakeholders from across the Commonwealth. It was signed into law last year. It convened over the course of the summer and came up with a set of robust recommendations on how to address sort of recognizing kind of the strengths of Virginia's public-private parent choice system and then saying, how can we prepare for this significant fiscal cliff?

[00:32:18] And again, as I noted before, with this risk of 35,000 kids losing their slots, it made recommendations like the idea of the capital incentive fund. It suggested things like a substitute pool, which are now actively pieces of legislation that are being reviewed by our General Assembly right now.

[00:32:38] So a ton of really good recommendations coming out of that new body that is charged in perpetuity with making recommendations on the financing of our public-private system. Now, since we've moved it over kind of to DOE and have fully established the measurement system and some of the other key components.

[00:33:03] Any other questions or comments? Go ahead, Ms. Holton. I just wanted to say, having worked with Jenna for a number of years now, we have overcome so many obstacles in the realm of early childhood education.

[00:33:22] And what I just would like to say is your leadership has been unmatched. It has been unmatched in every sense of anything that I could say, your professionalism, your dedication to this population of students and families.

[00:33:41] And I am so thankful that you are here and informing us and moving us in Virginia to places that I never thought that we would move before you came here. And I am grateful for the example that you have built for our education system birth through the highest and oldest learner in the Commonwealth.

[00:34:14] And so for that, we are grateful and will be forever in the Commonwealth of Virginia indebted to the service that you provided us. So thank you. Thank you. I would be remiss if I didn't recognize that we have just had the opportunity. We embody the public-private partnership within the broader team.

[00:34:32] And so huge thanks to my team, as well as our partners at the Early Childhood Foundation, the Promise Partnership, the Provider Advisory Council, and just the extraordinary private providers who have stepped up in incredible ways in the last five years.

[00:34:50] They make all this possible. Yes. Thank you. Partly, I just wanted to chime in on what you've already said, that your work, Jenna, has been, and your team's work has just been incredible on this. And I love that you all were essentially ahead of the, well, this has been, as you know, work coming over the

course of really almost a couple of decades in Virginia across different administrations, bipartisan, but also a federal state partnership. And you all, because of the hard work you personally have done and your

[00:35:25] team over the last two administrations, when the pandemic happened, and then as part of that, there was all of a sudden some really significant federal investment. You were ready for it and able to help us in Virginia use it well, such that we used the federal money to really soar the level of participation. And the participation growth since 2021, obviously largely funded by those federal dollars was incredible. And now to have the governor's proposed budget essentially carrying

[00:36:01] on that federal investment is just a wonderful thing. One question I wanted to ask is one of the extraordinary things you all have done as part of your quality effort is this effort to support professional development for staff and to help support, address staff turnover through these bonuses that the state, as I understand it, pays to those who participate in the, who complete the state's professional development. Is that in the budget, in the governor's budget, or is there some other way to continue that? That is a great question, and I feel like this is the pop quiz,

[00:36:40] because that was on the document, and I failed to mention it. Yes, there are continued investments. So, Ms. Hulton, what you're referring to is Recognize B5. This is a nationally recognized incentive. We were able to partner with the University of Virginia, who did a randomized control trial in Fairfax using federal dollars in the beginning and found that providing a direct to teacher incentive in child care helped cut turnover in half. And it was truly randomized. So, you know, the only thing that was different across these two populations was the receipt of this incentive. We found a null effect on school-based teachers, right, because they receive,

[00:37:19] you know, generally speaking, a more substantive wage versus at the time what child care teachers were making was functionally $10 to $12 an hour, which is not enough to support a family on. And so since then, we have been able to encourage and our legislators have responded by making a state investment. This year, Recognize B5, up to 16,900 educators are going to be eligible for up to $40 million. And this is across the state. And we do an educator survey and they talk about this being very powerful. And this is, they are not using this to buy fancy cars or to buy excess things.

[00:37:57] They are literally using this to pay medical bills for their own children or to cover a credit card bill. And so it's been very important. The governor, Building Blocks for Virginia's Families does preserve $10 million investment in each of the next two years, as well as preserving our investment in child care scholarships. So we don't require a bachelor's degree for any child care educator, but we do have an array of programs if folks are interested in pursuing following future education. And we are excited to be able to continue that very important program

[00:38:35] forward. And again, Recognize B5 rolled out at the same time as EQB5. So many of our educators say it was a big deal. As you might imagine, you know, for our school teachers who are used to classroom observation, this was less of a shift. It was appreciated because the measure is very age appropriate, right? So we weren't evaluating preschool teachers based on a tool that was built for fifth graders. It truly is built for teachers of three and four-year-olds. But for child care and family child care, this was an entirely new experience. And so Ms. Creasy's comments come initially sort of poignant because she knows how far we have come in terms of rolling out what is

[00:39:13] a very rigorous measure for settings that this was entirely new for, but being able to offer and recognize these individuals. And regardless of your credential, we consider you an educator. We don't call

you a daycare worker. We think of you as an educator. To be able to not only measure and provide feedback, this fall, we completed, as I'll share with you in the spring, but we completed just under 11,000 classroom observations across all of these settings.

[00:39:40] that represents between 60 and 80 minutes of observation of what kids are experiences and direct feedback for teachers in a way that many of our teachers have never received before and to be able to recognize um to both not only turnover reduce turnover through recognize b5 but also to recognize these individuals as educators um has truly been a success a bipartisan success for Virginia. And you said it's in the governor's proposed budget at $10 million a year. Is that the same amount that's already been allocated, or is that sufficient to sustain the same number

[00:40:17] of participants as we've done before? So right now, that's, I think, a question underway in the General Assembly. There's a delta. There's about $30 million difference between where the program is today and what is available in each of the years. So in other words, we're funding the Recognize to B5. I can't. Recognize B5. I can't do my acronyms. Recognize B5 is currently funded at $30 million a year. $40 million a year. At $40 and the proposal is $10 million. Yes, each year. I have three questions. I hope they're quick and two of them are related, so we'll ask them

[00:40:54] together. One is that, I mean, your slide was very compelling where these gaps start to occur way before they get to kindergarten we know they come like you know six three six months i mean they're opening incredibly early and it could be very um you know obviously it's it's discouraging so i guess one thing i'm curious about is are is it possible to identify these kids even earlier than kindergarten so you've got this patchwork of variety of child care centers across the state is there any way that we can somehow because i know you're using vkarp to all you know to

[00:41:30] identify them and get them going in K. But what about like, is there any kind of way that we can start identifying them even earlier than kindergarten? Absolutely. Can I jump in just for a second before you do that? Just to inform the conversation a little bit more, this has been years in the making with endless amounts of stakeholders involved. Many of them being involved literally on day one of birth. So we have people going into hospitals to work with

[00:42:05] families on a continuum. And so that I think is really something to highlight too, as we start to think about, we're not just grabbing that information when they come into an early childhood center or one of our VPI programs. But Jenna, you can.

[00:42:21] Yeah, so I think the first thing, Dr. Northern, is an important stat that we often talk about. When we look at the VKRP results, the children who come in least ready are often children from low-income households whose parents report no preschool experience.

[00:42:39] And so as Ms. Chrissy can sometimes attest, sometimes we say, well, we've ended up in this conversation of should it be in a school or should it be in a church versus recognizing that truly if we don't make that opportunity available to more families, families, that we know that our kids, particularly in our low-income households, are just, you know, two-thirds of them come in not ready, right? So it's almost a flip of the state average. And we think this is where choice is really important. We have incredible Virginia Preschool Initiative programs, but we also know that those are not, you know, available in every school, right? We also know that families might, you know, prefer a private setting or prefer a faith-based setting

[00:43:15] or something smaller. And so that focus on making more dollars available just to get everybody into preschool if they want it it would never be compulsory is i think number one number two is we have in uh during the pandemic uh expanded vkrp um and so we do have a three and four year old version it is required in virginia preschool initiative and mixed delivery right now we have been more flexible with child care subsidy for a variety of reasons just largely just the volume of change right so if you want to use it um head start and talk your subsidy we make it available to you, but all of our kids in Virginia Preschool Initiative and Mixed Delivery, when that system is

[00:43:54] fully built out, which is about another year, we'll know at the beginning and end of three-year and the beginning end of four, right? Never for stakes, right? This is just to support kids learning and development, engage families earlier on. But that's also important to be able to look at the growth within these years. Oftentimes we hear that if we were to evaluate every three-year, we'd see some version of a gap there. And then lastly, I think continuing to work and you know, working very closely with schools, right, who through early childhood special education really have the obligation from two and a half to kindergarten entry to find kids and connect them to services. And that continues to be, and we know our parents of our children with special

[00:44:33] needs, particularly during the pandemic, it was incredibly difficult. And so looking at how we partner with schools to understand, to identify early, to connect to services, and then make sure they have choice or all three S. So I love hearing that you have a version of VKRP that can start earlier than K. Like that's awesome. Um, real quickly, um, does Virginia have pre-K standards or ECE standards? Like where? Okay. And we have, they're called the, oh, I'm sorry. I interrupted you. No, no, I'm just saying, but I mean, are they like officially adopted by this body? Okay.

[00:45:07] All right. No, no, no, no, no. That's right. So they're the early learning and development standards. I think for at least another year or two off, they were reviewed by this body. They are comprehensive in nature. So they cover everything from early language. They go from birth to five. So it's pretty, you realize how much children grow in that period of time. And then we make sure that they're aligned with the kindergarten SOLs. Okay. And last question. I know you said there are consistent expectations across all these different providers. So what happens if they're not up to snuff are you finding their particular things drivers of quality and how

[00:45:45] do you kind of help them improve absolutely so we have two two uh parts of the division that address this so we have an office of child care health and safety and they license all of our private child care um and either regulate or license our our family day homes and so they do uh two inspections annually and they work very closely with providers to make sure that they're following all of the basic health and safety regulations and um you know oftentimes if they're deep health and safety concerned we're not even talking about learning we're really working with them to make sure that these are safe places for children to be and there's a set of consequences you know if we

[00:46:22] work with a provider up and leading to kind of revocation if you um are not willing to make the changes in order to keep kids safe and we work really closely with the superintendent with the board and with we've worked with a task force of providers and pediatricians to strike that right balance of what is needed but not going too far as well making it hard to operate on the quality side for those those programs that take public dollars what vqb5 has two components so the first is we use a nationally recognized classroom observation tool the class it is a rigorous

[00:46:58] measure. We went from, I think, under 100 observations happening in the state in 2018 to just under 19,500. And we are on track for just over 30,000 this year. So it's an extraordinary insight in what children are experiencing. We have, as we'll share with you with the NORA this spring, we have different levels of quality. And for those programs that we have the ratings out this fall that do not meet expectations there will be required to do improvement planning so we will come out there we will look at their class scores we will look at their use of curriculum 100 of

[00:47:37] those that scored in that area during the practice year we're using no curriculum right so that's an area where we will engage the other component of eqb5 is we have a choice of approved curriculum but you receive points if you are using one of those and we also know that folks couldn't afford curriculum. And so the state has made investments and there's several, including a state supported available curriculum. So an open educational resource called Stream in Three. And so we've been really focused in the last two years for childcare and family childcare programs that had no curriculum. So we share with this body two years ago, 55% of family childcare and 45% of

[00:48:15] childcare said we're using nothing, right? And so you roll out class and you give insight to teachers and you lay out the behaviors you want to see and then you come behind with a choice curriculum that really equips your teachers whether she's been doing it for years or whether she's brand new to think intentionally each day there's an infant toddler preschool version about supporting and learning development so we think that is where we're going to see the significant gains by saying to those that score very low something we need to work with you providing that support really focus on giving them the tools like we you know we can't say go back and get a bachelor's degree, that's simply not possible or affordable, but we will have practical tools to support you to

[00:48:55] improve your interaction scores and your use of curriculum, but do that kind of, and the other really important thing about VQB5 is you can see incremental improvement. Because these are sort of scores to three points, you'll be able to see the improvement as a system, and don't worry, we will when we bring you vqv5 we will bring you all the data and and and mr and i can certainly talk to you separately because we we it's a it's 130 slides and we go out and stay with it but we will spare you that we will say that um thank you so much very very impressive i know i know i know

[00:49:31] we do a data deep dive so we we you know across very uh comprehensive answers i appreciate it i i just have to say i have been in several states and no other state has a program that's built like this they can talk about this they can say they've done 30 000 class observations in the state and that they're providing that kind of professional development that kind of data feedback i'm incredibly honored and proud to work with jenna and the work that she's doing it is just groundbreaking across the country that we have that kind of support for our early learners so

[00:50:05] i just want to say thank you to jenna any other questions or comments dr sievert um this is more more of a curiosity. I absolutely echo the accolades, you and your team, and the great work being done. I also appreciate just like the rhythm of reporting we've received over the years on this journey, even before I was on the board, just the very thoughtful, just all those things are true.

[00:50:31] One of the other things you had to do was kind of integrate the system from the Commonwealth into the Department of Education, and so this is a really just low, low question, a little embarrassed to ask, but it appears to me that you're using nine regions, which probably predates coming to the department, whereas a lot of the work we do is eight. We certainly don't want to lose any trend data

that you're doing on your nine regions, but I just didn't know as we move forward, do we see any issues with alignment? I mean, I see where some of the boundaries are and whatnot, or again, it might just be that these are just totally different systems, and we just know we're

[00:51:06] talking about slightly different regions. Yeah, that's a great question, Dr. Siebert. So So we've tried to, we basically established in law the REDI regions, the importance of regional infrastructure, and the REDI regions are the entities that are responsible for building the relationships across the array of programs, making sure all these classroom observations occur, and the data is entered into Link B5, coordinating enrollment, and deepening family engagement.

[00:51:33] We really want to support parents as our children's first and most important educators, but it's better to do that at the regional level. And so they are funded via the Department of Education to make sure that they have folks that support family engagement and enrollment and then to get all of this work around VQB5 done.

[00:51:49] Those were derived via a competitive process based on where the classrooms were. And so there are some differences. We always have the ability to work very closely with the Virginia Early Childhood Foundation to kind of to make adjustments as we need be based on that. And then the good news about Recognize B5, because we capture the data all the way down to the classroom level, we can always slice and dice.

[00:52:13] So, for example, if a superintendent's region was like, I'd like to see the results from the VPI programs just for our region, it is very easy for us to pull that data. And we work very, very closely with the superintendents and make each other connected to their REDI regions.

[00:52:33] Thank you. And I'm not asking for any changes or modifications. You answered my question. Really, I think just language is important. These are the REDI regions. So I'm going to try to be clear in my language that I'm talking about ready regions, and that will be easy to differentiate from other regions.

[00:52:48] So that is helpful. But I have no doubt that you can put this data together in any form. Be careful what you ask for. Ms. Halton? Just back to the topic I raised with you before, I am worried about the child care workforce issues.

[00:53:07] And I do remember the slides you've given us in the past, essentially showing that before your efforts, before including this very significant recognition bonus, that we have essentially 100% turnover in the child care workforce, meaning that anything you train anybody on this year is out the window by next year because the people aren't there anymore.

[00:53:31] And so I just, I am recognizing that there's a lot of moving pieces here. Maybe there will be an increase in the minimum wage such that that will help raise up these jobs, but child care worker jobs are tough, underpaid jobs historically, and you all have helped really right the ship on that, and I would just hate to lose the benefit of that.

[00:53:55] And so I hope and trust you can come back and tell us that you're figuring out some solutions of how you're going to make the money go far, you know, how $10 million is going to do the work of $40 million or some other solution to the workforce issues going forward.

[00:54:11] No, we continue to measure and support our educators. And we know that even this morning, I was sitting in a subcommittee and they were talking about substitute pools and trying to sort of look at its

support for educators. And truly, we are seeing, and we've never seen before in the Commonwealth, that the supply of teachers is limiting how many children can be served.

[00:54:34] There was a childcare director this morning who said, I have an empty classroom and a wait list. Like that doesn't make sense, right? That like we've got to continue to support our very important early childhood workforce, right? Who are in this effort often is, you know, it's to support the workforce of the day and to build the workforce of tomorrow. That's a very important point.

[00:54:54] Jenna, just one final question for you. The pandemic has totally messed up my sense of years. So excuse me. But it might have been four or five years ago when we did that massive workforce study where we looked at education, we looked at, you know, pay scales and rates across the Commonwealth. Are we keeping up with that data pretty regularly? And is that something that's

[00:55:26] accessible so that the board could see, you know, what education looks like. Basically what I'm talking about is these regional diversifications in so many different facets of this particular workforce. Absolutely. So a couple of things on that. I mean, one, in fact, we have these really unique workforce profiles that we produced in partnership with the University of Virginia. So we have a multi-year research policy partnership with the University of Virginia. It's called Strengthening Early Education Partnerships, or C Partnerships, and they produce, so they are the

[00:56:04] ones who produce the report on Recognize B5, and they did the RCT, or the randomized study on that. They also do an annual workforce survey. So, for example, we've seen wages go up. However, when controlled for inflation that functionally they're just where they were you know pre-pandemic but we have um that data and they just produce uh grace they just produce some really interesting workforce profiles so the child care teacher in child care setting and family child care in schools what their background is you know what their average income is really information really

[00:56:39] interesting information on benefits and turnover and so we've got that data in addition to um producing reports on that and then so we'll continue to to invest in those surveys and that research policy partnership um and to uh capture some of that data through lengthy five so understanding i know and i keep telling everybody to wait for it but next year once this information is public for those of you who are new to the board we've been doing this for two years it's been a five-year ramp up of this accountability system but we did two practice years one practice year because we knew that's what was needed. And then we had a second practice year because of the pandemic. So even though we've done all this work, all of this data is private because we made a

[00:57:19] commitment to providers that this was about them learning the system. But we will be able, starting next year, to look at the relationship between compensation and turnover and quality. And even, you know, we'll be able to associate kids with those classrooms over time, Dr. Northern, and then we'll be able to sort of say growth, right? And so again, you know, I could geek out this but it's so important if you capture data down to the classroom level and you know which children are those classrooms and you capture the different facets of those those classrooms and then you connect it to a longitudinal data system the there's unlimited uh potential with with link b5 and then we have this long-standing partnership with the early childhood foundation and with the

[00:57:57] university of virginia to help us make sense of that data to help us work very closely with the the Ready Regions to build their capacity to use that data. And ultimately, VA also publishes and sort of elevates this work nationally. But I'll share that. I'll email the body, those workforce profiles, and you'll see

the difference between the experience of a preschool teacher and of a child care teacher. I think that would be really helpful. Thank you, at least for the perspective.

[00:58:24] So if there are no other questions or comments, thank you so much. Wonderful. Thank you all. you being here with us today. We are going to break for lunch here in just a minute, but Dr.

[00:58:40] Coons is going to give us a little bit of information. So even though we are at the Library of Virginia, I'm really excited that almost every member of the executive leadership team will be here to be introduced to the board and to have opportunities to share with the board.

[00:58:55] And we invite the executive leadership team and our English language arts presenters and anyone who's here to come join us for lunch and have opportunity to talk and share the work with the board. So we're excited to be here today. Okay, so I think I'm gonna give us until 1.30 to come back.

[00:59:12] Okay, all right, thank you.